

Where Gardens Begin

First steps for a calm, staged garden journey —
five principles we return to in every project.



On whose country

Gardener & Son acknowledges the Wurundjeri Woi-wurrung people as the Traditional Owners and ongoing custodians of the lands on which our studios stand, and on which the gardens in this guide are imagined.

We pay our respects to Elders past, present, and emerging. We recognise that sovereignty over this country has never been ceded — and that the deepest, most generous knowledge of how to live well with this place was here long before us, and remains here still.

To garden ecologically is, in some small way, to listen to that knowledge. We are still learning how to listen.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

This is not a checklist. It is a quiet companion for the first weeks of thinking about your garden.

Five principles follow. Each can be read in a few minutes. None of them requires a decision — only a moment of sitting with the question at the end.

When you are ready, the next conversation is whichever one feels easiest.

01

Start where you stand

A garden begins not with a plan, but with attention. Before any line is drawn or plant chosen, sit with the place. Note where the sun falls in the morning, where shadow gathers in the afternoon, which corners catch wind, which collect water.

The plants already growing, the trees on neighbouring blocks, the indigenous vegetation class beneath the soil — all are clues to what wants to thrive here.

The most expensive mistakes are made by gardens that ignored where they stood. The most resilient gardens are the ones that listened first. A season of watching is rarely wasted. It is, almost always, the most useful thing a garden can ask of you.

A companion tool — findmyecologicalgarden.com — will tell you which indigenous vegetation class lies beneath your address.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What does this place become at dawn, at noon, and at dusk?

02

Structure, then planting, then detail

Gardens that feel calm are usually built in the right order. Structure first — the trees that will live longest, the paths that decide how you move, the edges that hold beds apart from lawn or stone.

Planting next, layered into the structure: a canopy where shade is wanted, a midstorey for shelter, a ground layer that closes the soil. Detail last — the bench, the lamp, the gravel, the gate.

The opposite sequence is what creates the costly redos: a tree planted before the path is set, a feature added before the bones are sound. A staged pathway, taken patiently, almost always builds the garden you actually wanted.

A companion catalogue — heirloomgardenobjects.com — gathers the considered objects a garden grows around.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

If only the bones were built this year, would that be enough?

03

Indigenous first, exotic with intention

The plants that belong to a place have already passed the hardest tests — drought, fire, frost, the local soil's slow chemistry. Begin there.

The indigenous vegetation class beneath your address is a living catalogue of what wants to grow here, and a planting led by it tends to be hardier, more habitat-rich, and quietly more beautiful than its opposite.

Exotic plants are welcome — for fruit, fragrance, family memory, a colour that lifts a corner. But they earn their place by intention, not default. A garden built this way is not nostalgic; it is alive. It feeds birds. It holds soil. It belongs to the wider country it sits within.

A companion nursery — plantsofplace.com — propagates the indigenous species suited to where you garden.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What lived here, long before the fence?

04

Design for a rhythm of life

A garden is only as good as the time you can give it. The most beautiful planting plan, designed for hands that aren't there to tend it, becomes a quiet kind of grief.

So begin with the rhythm of actual life — the morning coffee, the school run, the weekend hours, the seasonal weeks of holiday. A garden can be designed to need very little, or to reward many hands. Both are honest.

What matters is that the garden you plant is the garden you can keep loving. The right rhythm is one where the work feels like ritual, not duty — small, repeated, mostly enjoyable. Everything else is the wrong rhythm.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

Which hour of the week will this garden belong to?

05

A garden is a long conversation

Gardens are never finished. The first three years set the structure. The next decade reveals which plants want to stay and which will quietly move on. By twenty years, the garden you began with has become something neither of you would have predicted — and that is the right outcome.

To garden well is to steward, not to own. The trees you plant will outlast your tenure. The soil you build will hold the next family's children.

Keep a small record — what was planted, what was lost, what surprised — and the garden becomes a document as much as a place. The most generous thing a garden can do is remember.

A longer record — ecologicalregistry.org — keeps the memory of gardens stewarded as ecological projects.

A QUESTION TO SIT WITH

What might this garden become, long after I have gone?

A BEGINNING

When you're ready

Some gardens begin with a phone call. Some begin years later, after a slow turning of the seasons. There is no wrong rhythm.

When you would like to talk, we are here. Without a clipboard. Without a sales pitch. Just a careful conversation about what your place might become.

THE STUDIOS

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